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The Construction of Achievement in Pursuit of Space.

Achievement is often defined as a milestone that has been reached, or a task completed but in terms of space travel the definition of achievement is altered as it can be representative of a reflection of goals, values or problems of a society or individual person's experience. The idea of "going to the moon" is presented in John F. Kennedy's "We Choose to go to the Moon" speech, and Verne's "From Earth to the Moon." as an achievement of humankind. While technological components are expressed in these texts, there is a far more symbolic meaning behind them. In Verne's fictional book, achievement is presented through satire to critique the overly obsessive ambition and pride that drives the characters to form a lunar mission, while Kennedy's speech constructs the achievement of a moon landing as a moral imperative, meaning a right of human progress to continue America's national purpose of exploration. He shapes the landing as a unifying challenge that represents American leadership during the Cold War. This paper examines not what the lunar landing achievement is necessarily in these texts but how this achievement is constructed through the rhetorical strategies used to motivate society or critique values of their time. In Kennedy's speech, he uses the rhetoric of unity, nationhood and identity to represent achievement while Verne uses satire, mockery and theatrical choices to represent achievement in the novel. First I will dive into some background of the texts, then explore the rhetorical choices that Kennedy and Verne use to construct achievement and its symbolic implications. Lastly I will compare these texts' similarities around the lunar landing and its achievements.

JFK's "We Choose to go to the Moon" is known for its incredible performance to attain

support from the American public in lunar exploration. During the Kennedy era, the Cold War brought mistrust, fear and an increasing competitive nature with other nations. The American people were in need of a reason to trust and confide in the U.S during this time. The background of the Cold War is important to understand for what achievement means in Kennedy's speech, and how his strategies allowed for him to deliver a speech that transformed the public to view a lunar landing not necessarily as a technological transformation but as a symbolic achievement of the U.S. First, the moon landing is represented as a symbolic achievement of humankind's ability to unify themselves, meaning that Kennedy uses the idea of nationhood and unity as a form of rhetoric to overshadow the separation in the country. Around the Apollo missions, in the backdrop of the Cold War there was a lot of fragmentation within the American public and so in order for unification to work, the American people need to believe in one common goal, in other words be in agreement with each other. Kennedy uses a unifying rhetoric to overwrite fragmentation within the country. In "Kennedy's Romantic Moon and its Rhetorical Legacy for Space Exploration", John Jordan explains that Kennedy knew that in order for the lunar landing to be possible, there needed to be an establishment of a common goal he states, "but it was the American people who would have to believe in the goal if a lunar landing were to have any chance at becoming a reality" (Jordan 211). This common goal can foster a sense of unity. In Kennedy's speech, he establishes a space of togetherness from the absolute very beginning, emphasizing that the American people are all in a collective state of mind; he does this by using the words "we" and "our." "We meet at a college noted for knowledge…we stand in need of all three, for we meet in an hour of change…" (Kennedy 1), and "The greater our knowledge increases…our collective comprehension" (Kennedy 1). With the words "we" and "us" Kennedy alters the perspective of "American vs. American" to "American vs. the world." This allows for

the public to stray away from the idea that the only way to get to the moon is through NASA's efforts only, but that it requires the American people to view each other as a collective people. Kennedy's representation of a lunar landing is a communal achievement, a victory that is for all of "us."

Apart from establishing a sense of unity, the Cold War served as a backdrop for a recalling a sense of national pride and creating a legacy for those of us in the future. This is prevalent at the beginning of the speech where Kennedy uses a different perspective of time to build a sense of pride within the public. Kennedy condenses the time of human evolution to about half a century or fifty years:

> "The printing press came this year, and then less than two months ago, during this whole 50-year span of human history, the steam engine provided a new source of power. Newton explored the meaning of gravity. Last month electric lights and telephones and automobiles and airplanes became available. Only last week did we develop penicillin and television and nuclear power, and now if America's new spacecraft succeeds in reaching Venus, we will have literally reached the stars before midnight tonight" (Kennedy 1).

By changing the perspective of time, he emphasizes just how much progress has been made throughout history. He transforms progress into something achievable in a blink of time, condensing all of human effort creates an atmosphere of pride and motivation to continue to do what Americans do. By finishing the paragraph with "we will have literally reached the stars before midnight tonight" he defines going to the moon as an inevitable moment in time, something that the U.S will look back on as they continue their way in making history. Kennedy establishes the achievement of lunar landing as a destined result of human progress, natural and inevitable. This paragraph also puts the U.S at the center of progress, note that Kennedy does not mention other nations' significant progress. This is important because Jordan states, "Questions of international prestige shadowed America's space program…there was still a sense of needing

to reclaim lost national pride" (212). Kennedy understood this, and by centering progress with the U.S there is a sense of redemption and recovery through the achievement of a lunar landing. A few sentences down, Kennedy states, "By this city of Houston, this state of Texas, this country of the United States was not built by those who waited and rested…this country was conquered by those who moved forward–and so will space" (Kennedy 1).

This landing in space equals American superiority over the other nations. With the Cold War bringing out the competitive nature of several countries, achievement in space directly correlates with America gaining an upper hand symbolically and technologically compared with other countries. This is prevalent when Kennedy states, "...and no nation which expects to be the leader of other nations can expect to stay behind in this race for space"(1) To live up to the American ideals and even surpass them is Kennedy's representation of achievement. He does this by using the "New Frontier" rhetorical strategy. In this speech, Kennedy invokes American ideals that consist of freedom, progress and discovery by noting America's progress such as penicillin, science, noting that the speech takes place in Rice University, a place of knowledge and learning. Kennedy states, "Those who came before us made certain that this country rode the first waves of the industrial revolution…we mean to be a part of it–we mean to lead it." (2) This rhetorical strategy allows for the public to have a sense of discovery, exploration, to venture out just like their ancestors did before them. This viewpoint places the moon as a reachable destination, something that the American public has done before by "riding the first waves of the industrial revolution" or "first wave of modern invention"(Kennedy 2). Jordan states, "it allowed him to frame risks as adventures and contemporary Americans as intrepid pioneers" (214). This constructs achievement as something that is a performance of national pride, something that Americans can do now, and have always done in the past.

I mentioned that achievement took on a more symbolic meaning as a trip to the moon for Kennedy meant national pride, unity and legacy for the U.S. While this was a great strategy, it was not something that was accepted by everyone. In fact, the very approach of establishing the lunar landing or a trip to space as an achievement that had symbolic overtones was precisely what drew criticism from its opponents. Jordan quotes President Eisenhower's viewpoint, "The respected former president and general publicly proclaimed, 'Anyone who would spend $40 billion in a race to the moon for national prestige is nuts'" (212). This is important because it asks,"What constitutes an achievement?" For critics like Eisenhower an achievement is one that has physical implications such as a direct measurable impact. These opposing views highlight the tension between rhetorical achievement and concrete physical results.

Achievement having symbolic overtones is what is being criticized in "From Earth to the Moon" by Jules Verne. Here, achievement is being presented through his rhetoric of satire, mockery and obsession of pride. The achievement of a lunar landing in this novel has encompassed a more symbolic approach as the Gun Club's main drive for constructing a lunar module is to regain a sense of pride and superiority within themselves and the other nations. The book opens with the explanation of the Gun Club, how they were created, what they did and how Barbicane gave them the task of creating a cannon to launch a projectile to the moon. Verne already establishes the competitive nature of the Gun Club and how they are representative of America as a whole which I will develop later in this paper. "Now when an American has an idea he looks for another American who shares it…That was how it happened in Baltimore…That was the nucleus of the Gun Club" (Verne 2). Verne uses the Gun Club as a sort of embodiment of American Militarism,

"Once the Gun Club had been founded, it was easy to imagine the results produced by the Americans' inventive genius. Their cannons took on colossal proportions…All these inventions outstripped the timid instruments of European artillery…"(Verne 3).

This militarism has become a cultural identity of America, Verne makes sure to add the big cannons and to note the missing limbs or areas from the people of the Gun Club as it reinforces that pride, and fierceness of them. These traits then foster a competitive environment, as there is a sense of superiority within the Gun Club. In "Jules Verne's America", the author Arthur Evans presents in his paper the implications of Verne's perspective of America, but also why he thinks of America in a certain way. He states that, Verne believes, "For Americans, no construction project can ever be too large or too difficult:" (36). This is shown through Verne's book as he states, "In America, everything is easy, everything is simple, and mechanical difficulties are dead before they are born"(Verne 19). This is important because from the very start, the presentation of achievement is not being constructed as practical but rather one that is rooted in pride and superiority. Verne sets up the optimistic tone to convey that the success of the Gun Club is not necessarily one of meaningful progress but more as a sort of illusion of control over their competition. This tone has satirical undertones that Verne implies to critique the American representation of achievement

With the lunar landing representing a symbolic meaning, within the novel there is also a mockery of scientific rationalism, that includes blind ambition and ignorance towards the science or technology of going to the moon. This is shown through the ignorance of the dangerous work of building the projectile. "Several workers, it is true, paid with their lives for the rashness that is inherent in such dangerous work; but those deplorable accidents are impossible to avoid, and Americans are not inclined to worry about such details" (109). Verne explains what is more important to America, and mocks their prioritization of a collective group's dreams rather than

an individual person. This represents Barbicane's and the Gun Club's blind ambition towards this project of launching a projectile into the moon. Also, this represents the critique that Verne is doing about the moon landing as a symbolic achievement. In "Shooting for the Moon: Méliès, Verne, Weils, and the Imperial Satire." Sadner states, "Miller points to the ridiculous portrayal of the Gun Club and "their blind inability to see their project as anything more than target practice on a cosmic scale" as proof of Verne's satirical intent" (8). This reinforces the idea that going to the moon has the same ideological implications as war, and simply serves as an extension of war. Miller refers to the moon landing as a "target practice" it removes it from it being for a scientific purpose and leans towards a mock achievement of pride rather than to serve humanity such as the penicillin like mentioned in Kennedy's speech.

The leader of the Gun Club, Barbicane is overly charismatic who is more deeply rooted in reasserting that American power, and pride. In the speech that Barbicane gives to the Gun Club he states, "You also know that, practically speaking, the strength of cannons and the expansive power of gunpowder are unlimited…it might not be impossible to shoot a projectile to the moon" (18). In his speech, he manages to make a connection between war weapons, and how they can potentially be used to go to the moon. Barbicane's rhetorical power does not come from solely logic, but with his ability to stir patriotic sentiment across the general public. He also successfully uses the lunar mission achievement as a conquest expedition that the Gun Club can exert their war power into. This makes the achievement of the lunar landing one of performance of national pride, and not necessarily for the benefit of scientific knowledge. In "Shooting for the Moon: Méliès, Verne, Weils, and the Imperial Satire.", David Sadner quotes Walter Miller who wrote "Afterword." *From the Earth to the Moon Direct in Ninety-seven Hours and Twenty Minutes,* he states "What better way to emphasize that the moonshot is a spinoff of the U.S.

military might than to launch it from a cannon?" (Miller 8). This was a comment explaining the questions as to why Verne used "cannons" and didn't call them or define them as "rockets." It highlights the war undertones, critiquing that the lunar landing is an extension of the military. This reinforces the idea that the achievement of the lunar landing is not for scientific exploration but is for pride, and to show superiority among other nations. Using Barbicane, Verne mocks the way figures can use their platform to bring absurd ideas into a "possible" form, using it as a way to fuel nationalistic pride into the Gun Club. David Sadner states,"The imperial project is reimagined on a cosmic scale, a scale that tops war with a simply terrestrial foe and promises the unheard of glory of the conquest of space" (7). This reimagining of the lunar landing still holds the same ideological implications of war such as dominance, superiority and nationalism. Barbicane is simply changing the military conquest that the Gun Club knows to a "cosmic conquest" that promises them those same ideological implications of war on Earth. This is important to note because by satirizing Barbicane as a figure Verne critiques the construction of the lunar landing as something that preserves or increases national vanity and not necessarily for a physical impact to mankind.

Kennedy's Speech and Verne's "From Earth to the Moon" have different rhetorical strategies when constructing achievement. With Kennedy he uses a more politically based motivation and achievement is based on a moral imperative, while Verne uses satirical rhetoric to critique the construction of achievement as symbolic, competitive and superior; they both approach to represent achievement as something merely symbolic. In "Jules Verne's America" , Evans states, "Americans also represented for Verne a race of people who exemplified the very best of personal qualities: strength of body, energy of spirit…" (37). Barbicane represents a couple of those qualities in "From Earth to the Moon", and what is interesting is that Evans point

can be representative of Kennedy as a leader as well. Both Barbicane and Kennedy construct the lunar landing that needs to be supported and engaged by the public. Lastly, both texts frame a sort of heroic narrative of going to the moon, Barbicane leads the Gun Club and at the end of the novel he partakes in launching. Kennedy frames his speech as if America needs to be the heroic country that has always been destined to lead the rest of the nation, and should be the first to go to the moon. This heroic narrative reinforces that achievement is constructed and taken as a more symbolic approach rather than a physical one as both texts focus on the ideological implications that the moon landing will deliver. “From Earth to the Moon” creates achievement as a symbol of pride and superiority and is shown through satire to critique the ambition and pride of the Gun Club as they approach their lunar mission. Kennedy’s speech constructs the achievement of a moon landing as a moral imperative that the U.S needs to achieve to continue fulfilling their exploration through time. This is shown by the rhetoric of making the speech a journey. In both of these texts, achievement has taken on a more symbolic approach of fulfillment towards the American people. This construction causes questions “what constitutes achievement?” and does taking on a symbolic meaning result in better fulfillment or cause more concern?

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